personal risks they take upon themselves are the highest we can conceive of in human society in general. The (classic) combatants work alone in a target country, and their “personal weapons” are their passport and cover story. For any error, they are liable to pay with their lives. Therefore, the responsibility of the person who sends them on their missions is also higher than in any other field, including in the case of military commanders sending their soldiers into battle. In order to maintain the combatant’s personal security and to extract his or her full potential, a doctrine developed regarding the operating of combatants, relieving him or her of all daily worries. The unit takes care of all of the family’s needs and releases the combatant from all administrative affairs; it provides him or her with the ultimate professional team, consisting of an intelligence officer, an operations officer, a communications officer, a weapons and technology officer, and the expert in charge of the cover story. All of these roles are the domain of the runner, who is the combatant’s go-to person twenty-four hours a day, 365 days a year. The runner represents the unit’s collective wisdom. He is the combatant’s friend and confidant, his or her supporter and consoler, the briefer and the questioner, the admirer and the critic. If you will, the runner is the link between the combatant’s authentic life and his or her operational life.

Some will say, perhaps with a hint of cynicism, that the things I am saying belong to the romantic period of the unit and that today the circumstances are different and needs are different and capabilities are different. My response to this is that so-called romanticism is an eternal value, and one that must be preserved, because this is the only way to maintain the ultimate balance of security and cost/ benefit over time, with the emphasis being on the phrase “over time.”

A word about combatants with families.

First of all, it would be impossible to exist without them, because it is inconceivable that the unit be operated only by single people. Therefore, the unit, and especially the system that operates it, must create the maximum balance between the demands of the job and the duty of the combatant toward his or her family. On the basis of past experience, I would like to state that whenever there is any question about the calculations involved in maintaining this balance, then there is no doubt that family comes first. Bad decisions on this subject cause damage—sometimes serious damage—that ultimately affect the viability of an operation.